

Over the course of its operations, the Acworth Committee asked the opinions of 142 witnesses, including 48 railwaymen and 19 government officials. The members also visited Madras, Bombay, Delhi, Lucknow, Kanpur, and Lahore to collect evidence. They reconvened in London to undertake further discussions and after due deliberations with all sections of society, professionals, the government, and railwaymen in India and in Britain, the committee's report was submitted in mid-1921.

The recommendations

On the subject of management, the members unanimously advocated that it should be based in India and not London. To this effect, the committee recommended that the contracts with the companies be terminated at their respective expiry dates. It was however divided about the specific system of management in India. While some of its members preferred direct State management, others recommended that some management be given to companies domiciled in India. With respect to finance, all members agreed that it was intertwined with the decision on management. They also unanimously supported a complete overhaul of the financial system, including separation of the Railway Budget from the General Budget of the State, and agreed on the methods for raising new capital. Members who advocated some degree of private participation in management also provided additional methods for raising capital. On the rest of the matters, the committee was united in its decisions.

The Railway Board

The committee recommended major restructuring in the Railway Board's composition and suggested that it be renamed the Railway Commission. It provided further suggestions related to administration and control, such as appointing a Member of Council at the head of the Railway Department and the creation of a Department of Communications, which would include railways, with an exclusive member of the Viceroy's Council looking after it.

Other suggestions included relieving the Railway Department from the control of the India Office and the Government, except while dealing with finance and general policy, delegation of routine management to local railway administration, and the establishment of Central and Local